

D&D Arena — The Game, At A Glance

3v3 PvP D&D 5e. Pre-built characters, locked rules, two-hour matches. Drop-in friendly.

D&D Arena strips a normal D&D session down to the part that's fun in 90 seconds — pick your team, prep in town, fight in the arena, see who's still standing. No campaign, no character creation, no half-hour rules debates. A first-timer and a 20-year DM can sit at the same table and both have a good time.

1. The Two-Phase Loop

Every match runs the same shape. Two phases, in order, every time:

- **Phase 1 — The Town.** Prep. Your team has 60 minutes and 500 gp pooled to spend across six town locations — shop, train, gamble, research, deal with the black market, hunt the hidden catacombs. Decide what your team needs before the fight starts.
- **Phase 2 — The Arena.** Fight. Both teams place their three characters on a battle map and roll initiative. 90-second turns, ten-round cap. Whoever drops the other team first, wins.

Each phase has its own one-pager (this is #1; #2 is The Town; #3 is The Arena).

2. What Winning Looks Like

Team Deathmatch. One win condition, no draft, no special objectives. The first team to drop all three opposing characters takes the match. “Dropped” means at 0 HP and unconscious — same as standard 5e (three failed death saves and you're out).

If neither team is wiped by the end of round 10, every character drops to 1 HP for a sudden-death round 11. Tied after that, the match is a draw.

3. How Picking Works

You don't build a character. You pick one off the roster.

- **The roster:** 12 pre-built characters, one per PHB class — Barbarian, Bard, Cleric, Druid, Fighter, Monk, Paladin, Ranger, Rogue, Sorcerer, Warlock, Wizard. All Level 3, balance-tuned for the format.
- **Blind pick:** Each team privately picks 3 characters. Both teams reveal at the same time. **Mirrors are allowed** — both teams can show up with the same Fighter and that's fine.
- **No build time, no system mastery tax:** sit down, pick three names, you're playing.

4. The Rules Tweaks You Should Know

The format is 5e — but five things are tuned for tournament play. These apply to every character on the roster:

- **Level 3**, Point Buy 27, no multiclassing, no magic items at the start.
- **+10 HP buffer** on top of base — keeps fights from ending on a single unlucky crit.
- **No Extra Attack** at this level (Level 3 RAW). Casters and burst classes are relatively stronger.
- **Sleep is banned**. 5d8 against Level 3 HP totals = team-wipe risk.
- **Sharpshooter / Great Weapon Master**: -3 to hit / +6 damage (not -5 / +10).

Full variant doc: `rules-variant-level-3.md` in the Discord.

5. The Numbers

Metric	Value
Teams	3v3
All characters	Level 3
Pre-built picks	12 (one per PHB class)
Town phase	60 minutes
Arena cap	10 rounds + 1 sudden-death
Whole match	2–3 hours

“Like a quick chess match — but with fireballs.”

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